

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Bedtime Routine Picture Cards

Print, cut and stick at child height · Ages 2–4

Toddlers cooperate more when they know what comes next. Stick these steps on the wall in order, and let your child point to each one as you go.

What the research found

- ○ Children with a nightly bedtime routine fell asleep faster, woke less and slept longer, and more nights of routine meant better sleep (Mindell et al., 2015).

The routine (about 30 minutes)

- ○ 1. Bath or wash up
- ○ 2. Pyjamas (two to choose from)
- ○ 3. Brush teeth
- ○ 4. Toilet
- ○ 5. One or two books (child chooses)
- ○ 6. Cuddle and the same goodnight song
- ○ 7. Lights off, night light on

An hour before bed

- ○ Lights low
- ○ Screens off
- ○ Calm play: puzzles, books, drawing

If they keep getting up

- ○ Walk them back calmly with few words
- ○ Same response every time
- ○ Offer a 'one more hug' token they can use once

How much sleep?

Children aged 1–2 years generally need 11–14 hours in 24 hours (including naps), and ages 3–5 need 10–13 hours. Talk to your paediatrician about persistent sleep problems.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Mindell, J. A., Li, A. M., Sadeh, A., Kwon, R., & Goh, D. Y. T. (2015). Bedtime routines for young children: A dose-dependent association with sleep outcomes. Sleep, 38(5), 717–722.
World Health Organization (2019). Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 years of age.

General information, not medical advice.